

25SMCV03117 25SMCV03117

County: los-angeles

Division: Civil Law and Motion

Department: M

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Case Number: 25SMCV03117 Hearing Date: August 4, 2026 Dept: M

CASE NAME: Wright v. Smith, et al.

CASE

NO.: 25SMCV03117

MOTION: Motion to be Relieved

HEARING

DATE: 8/4/2026

LEGAL STANDARD

The court may order that an attorney be changed or substituted at any time before or after judgment or final determination upon request by either client or attorney and after notice from one to the other. (CCP § 284(2).) The attorney seeking to withdraw must take “reasonable steps to avoid reasonably foreseeable prejudice to the rights of the client, including giving due notice to the client, allowing time for employment of other counsel.” (Cal. Rules of Prof. Conduct, 3-700(A)(2). See, e.g., Vann v. Shilleh (1975) [holding withdrawal prejudicial where attorney withdraw from the representation of defendant on the Friday before trial began the following Monday].) “The determination whether to grant or deny a motion to withdraw as counsel lies within the sound discretion of the trial court.” (Manfredi & Levine v. Superior Court (1998) 66 Cal.App.4th 1128, 1133.)

An application to be relieved as counsel must be made on Judicial Counsel Form MC-051 (Notice of Motion and

Motion), MC-052 (Declaration), and MC-053 (Proposed Order). (CRC 3.1362(a), (c), (e).) The requisite forms must be served “on the client and on all parties that have appeared in the case.” (CRC, 3.1362(d).) When a client is served by mail, the attorney's declaration must indicate that the client's address was confirmed within the last 30 days and how it was confirmed. (Id.) If the attorney is unable to confirm the client's current address, the declaration must state the reasonable efforts made within the last 30 days to obtain the client's current address. (Id.)

Additionally, the declaration “must state in general terms and without compromising the confidentiality of the attorney client relationship why” a motion is brought instead of filing a substitution of attorney. (CRC, 3.1362(c).)

ANALYSIS

Counsel Cyndie Chang, Luke McLoughlin, and Duane Morris LLP moves to be relieved as counsel of record for Southern California Hospital at Culver City.

Counsel submits all the mandatory forms. Counsel did not fill out paragraph of the MC-051 form. However, the other forms provide the omitted information. Counsel states that an irreparable breakdown of the attorney-client relationship has occurred. Counsel states that the client is going through bankruptcy and it lacks funds for legal defense. Counsel served his client by mail at its last known address, which was confirmed within the past 30 days by the Bankruptcy Plan Administrator. Given that trial is not set, the Court does not find that the client will be prejudiced by the withdrawal. Additionally, counsel must fill out the blank paragraphs on the MC-053 form (i.e., ¶¶ 2-10) prior to service on the client, including notice of the upcoming hearings.

Accordingly, the motion is GRANTED.

The order is effective upon the filing of the proof of service of the order on the client. Until then, counsel remains counsel of record.